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Brigade Commander
Containing the Fire

'The mantra for success in counterterrorism/insurgency operations is an "iron fist" for the terrorists and a "velvet glove" for the people.'

On New Year's day in 1991, I took the flight from Delhi to Srinagar for my new assignment. As the plane flew over the beautiful snow-clad Pir Panjal range, I remembered the first time I had crossed the Banihal Pass in 1958 as an excited wide-eyed teenager. A lot of water had flown down the Jhelum in the past three decades. I had just been promoted as a brigadier and was on my way to take over the command of 79 Mountain Brigade. This was my third posting in J&K and the most important of them all, as Kashmir was aflame.

The picketing on the roadsides and heavy security during army movements made it look like a war zone. It was the peak of insurgency in Jammu and Kashmir. I could sense the tension in the air. It was going to be a make-or-break assignment for me and the intensity of operations was going to be immense. We were caught up in a classic case of irregular warfare – a proxy war and insurgency where the lead role was being played by non-state actors and their masters were across the LoC.

Pakistan was the mastermind of this stratagem, also referred to as 'Operation Topac'. Innocent Kashmiris who were losing their lives were like sacrificial goats, a price that did not hurt Pakistan directly. The jehadis from Pakistan or other countries who were ready to die for the 'cause' were cannon fodder produced by jehadi factories in Pakistan or PoK. They were brainwashed and sent across the LoC